



TRIGGER: (Above) Swami Saraswati before his brutal murder; (right) militant Hindus on the rampage; (below) the torched Breka church

Photographs by MANISH AGNIHOTRI



ror she has been through: one of her brothers Abhimanyu Nayak was burnt alive.

In camp after camp, the villagers said they heard the attackers shouting that they were simply taking revenge for the Christmas day violence last year. On that day clashes between the vip supporters and Christians had erupted when some Christians tried to set up a gate in front of a temple in Brahmanigaon village. When Saraswati visited the site, he was allegedly attacked. Around 800 houses were damaged in the violence that followed and 580 families were displaced. It left five dead.

This time, there is an air of mystery around the controversial swami's killing. Despite being a high-risk security threat, on the night he was killed, his bodyguard was on leave while four unarmed constables attached to his security had gone to a nearby market. Despite the fact that there were as many as eight attempts on his life, the 84-year-old swami's administration ignored his security. The swami was the Hindutva icon in the state, spearheading a crusade supporting implementation of the ban on cow slaughter, spreading Hindu teachings among tribal youth and opposing forced conversion. Curiously, just three days before his assassination, the swami had received threatening letters and even

though the police were informed, security around him was not tightened. His killing resulted in the mass upsurge of fanatics who presumed that Christians had a hand in his death.

Orissa is no stranger to religious violence. In January 1999, Australian missionary Graham Stains, and his two sons, were burnt alive in Keonjhar district by Hindu fanatics led by Dara Singh. In 1998, 5,000 anti-conversion fanatics attacked the Christian-dominated Ramgiri-Udaygiri in Gajapati district. Since then, numerous incidents have been recorded, including those of murder and arson. Otherwise too, the rss's history in modern Orissa is a violent one. Thus the Kandhamal riots were not unexpected.

However, the recent violence is unparalleled. Satyan Diggal, now in a relief camp, says, by August 27, most of the houses in his village were gutted. "Fearing death, I agreed to reconvert but once I came to the camp I changed my mind and left everything to God. We are Christians by conviction and not by force."

There is, in fact, no evidence that Christians were behind the swami's death. Even the claim by the Maoists that they were behind the murder has failed to stop extremist Hindus from keeping up the attacks against the converts. The Bajrang Dal's Subhash Chauhan and BJP state chief Suresh Pujari see no reason for the Naxalites to kill the swami. "Why should Naxalites kill him? What was the motive?" asks Pujari.

Chief Minister Naveen Patnaik has been totally ineffective, first burying his head in the sand, then by belatedly visiting the affected areas and announcing a commission of inquiry—the standard bureaucratic practice which leads to nowhere. The chief minister's attitude has led to the Congress, the main Opposition, issuing a warning that the state was being plunged into a communal cauldron to help the BJP, the ruling partner, to expand its base by

CYCLE OF HATE

1998: 5,000 fanatics attack Ramgiri-Udaygiri and destroy 92 dwellings and a church.

1999: Australian missionary Graham Stains and his two minor sons are burnt alive in Manoharpur. A catholic nun is gang-raped in Mayurbhanj and a priest is killed in Jamabani.

2007: On Christmas-eve, mobs attack Christians in Kandhamal. Following attack on Swami Lakshmanananda, 800 houses are damaged, 580 families are displaced. Five are killed.